

Rath RPG

Rath Overdrive

Erratic Eye Games

© 2024 Erratic Eye Games. RATH RPG™ is a trademark of Erratic Eye Games.

Creative Commons License

Rath RPG is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>

Acknowledgments & Attribution

Rath RPG is based on Knave by Ben Milton, licensed under CC BY 4.0.

Original work: Knave © 2018 Ben Milton

Published by Erratic Eye Games

Thank you for playing Rath RPG!

Rath Overdrive

The Rider expansion for Rath RPG. Empowered champions, modular gear-driven transformations, and the dramatic buildup arcs of tokusatsu hero fiction.

A **Rider** is a person bonded to a transformation device — a **Driver** — that grants them dramatically enhanced ability for short windows. While transformed (in **Henshin**), a Rider is a focused and dangerous combatant whose power is themed by the **Inserts** loaded into their Driver.

Riders are not mages. They do not cast spells. Their power lives in their gear, and in the momentum of the fight itself.

Everything a Rider tracks: one number (**Charge**), the Inserts in their Driver, and how many transformations they have left today. That's it — it fits on a normal character sheet.

Setting: Rath Overdrive assumes a modern-day game. Use **Appendix A** of the Players Handbook for occupations, gear, and tone; this book adds only the Rider layer on top. It reflavours cleanly into any setting as a “blessed champion” archetype with GM approval.

1. Becoming a Rider

There are two ways in.

Start as one. Take **Henshin** at character creation, where it costs **both** of your starting aptitudes. You begin play already bonded to a Driver, already able to transform — and with nothing else. Everything you can do that an ordinary person can't comes out of the belt. That's the trade, and it's the right one for a campaign that opens with the Driver already on your hip.

Because two slots buy what one otherwise would, a creation Rider tops out one aptitude short of everyone else. In exchange, you have been doing this long enough that it comes easily: **you transform with 1 additional Charge** — 4 instead of 3, or 6 instead of 5 with Reinforced Core.

Become one. Take **Henshin** as an Advanced Aptitude at level 3, 5, 7, or 9, the normal way. Your character was someone before they were a Rider, and they keep being that person underneath. Finding the Driver is a story you get to play through rather than one you write in your backstory.

Either way, the rest of the tree is Advanced Aptitudes taken at 3, 5, 7, or 9 as usual. A specialist can take all four.

- **Henshin** (*required entry*) — You are bonded to a Driver. As an action, transform. You may Henshin **L times per long rest**. While transformed you have **+2 AC** and advantage on tests to resist fear, intimidation, and mental influence. You transform at **3 Charge**, your Charge cap is **6**, and your Driver has **1 Insert slot**.
- **Expanded Driver** (*requires Henshin*) — Your Driver gains **+1 Insert slot**. May be taken twice, to a maximum of three slots.

- **Reinforced Core** (*requires Henshin*) — Your Charge cap rises to **8**, and you transform at **5 Charge** instead of 3.
- **Finisher Mastery** (*requires Henshin*) — Your Finisher deals **+1d6**, and immediately after using one you gain **1 Charge**. Spent everything? The Driver gives you just enough back to still be standing.

Multiclassing: apart from the creation option above, Henshin uses Advanced Aptitude slots like any other path. A Rider can also be a Hedge Mage, Chartomancer, or Circle Mage, but four slots across two paths spreads thin. Pure Riders specialise.

Starting at level 1. A Rider who begins play as one is powerful in a way no other level 1 character is — but narrowly. **L** is 1, so you get **one transformation per day**; you have no other aptitudes at all; and while you start each Henshin at 4 Charge, your opening Finisher is only 5d6. Reaching the big numbers still takes rounds of fighting, and out of Henshin you are an ordinary person with a belt. If it feels too strong at your table, the dial is the same as always: drop the Finisher to **(Charge spent)d6**.

2. Charge

Charge is the whole system. One number, from 0 to your cap. It only exists while you are transformed, and it does four jobs at once:

Charge is...	Which means
Fuel for your Inserts	Spending makes you fragile
Fuel for your Finisher	Spending it all leaves you one hit from powering down
Your transformation's timer	At 0, the next hit ends it
Your buffer against anti-Rider attacks	Getting hit refuels you <i>and</i> threatens you

Because of the last two, a Rider who disengages loses their transformation. You cannot kite, hide, or wait it out. **You have to stay in the fight.**

Building Charge

Trigger	Charge
Strike — attack normally, hit or miss	+1
Charge up — attack, and forgo <i>all</i> damage from it	+2
You are hit by an attack, or take a hit for an ally via Protect	+1
The GM awards a cinematic beat — a rival’s challenge answered, a civilian saved, a named attack called out	+1 (once or twice a scene)

You cannot exceed your cap. Charge does not carry between transformations.

This is the trade. A Rider who wants a huge Finisher has to spend rounds dealing no damage to get there. Burst is bought with sustain, at a fixed rate, and it balances itself — you do not need to adjudicate it.

Spending Charge

Charge pays for **Inserts** (Section 5) and the **Finisher** (Section 4). Both are optional; a Rider who spends nothing simply fights on with +2 AC and a full pool.

Losing Charge

Ordinary attacks damage HP as normal. Some enemies carry **anti-Rider attacks** that strip Charge instead (Section 6).

At 0 Charge you are still transformed — but barely. This is a Rider’s last stand:

- You keep your +2 AC and everything else Henshin gives you
- You **no longer gain Charge from being hit**
- You **do** still gain Charge from striking, charging up, and cinematic beats — land a blow and you’re back in the fight
- **Any damage you take ends the transformation.** You take the damage as normal to HP, and you are forced out

Spending your pool does *not* detransform you. Only taking a hit at 0 does.

3. Henshin and Detransformation

Transforming is an **action**. It never fails while you hold your Driver — there is no roll.

You drop out of Henshin in one of three ways:

Trigger	Effect
Voluntary	Free action, any time. Charge is lost
Damage taken while at 0 Charge	Forced out. The damage applies to HP as normal. You are dazed for one round — you may move, but take no actions
HP reduced to 0	Forced out, and you enter Rath's at-0-HP rules as normal (CON test DC 12)

Re-transforming costs another use of Henshin. With none left, you are done for the day.

Without your Driver you cannot Henshin. Taking a Rider's Driver is a story beat, never a routine combat action — it needs real setup, an opportunity such as a grapple or an ambush, and an opposed test at major disadvantage. Destroying one is a campaign event, not a tactical outcome.

4. The Finisher

Every Rider has one, whatever their Inserts. Name it at the table.

Finisher — Action. Spend any amount of Charge. Deal **(Charge spent + 1)d6** damage to one target in near range.

Spend 3, deal 4d6. Spend 6, deal 7d6.

Emptying your pool does not power you down — but it leaves you at 0 Charge, where **the next hit that lands ends the transformation**. That's the decision the Finisher really asks: cash out everything for the biggest number and finish the fight *now*, or hold a point back and stay in it.

A Rider standing at 0 Charge, everything spent, still swinging, is the shot the whole genre is built around. Let it happen.

5. Inserts

Inserts are the modular engines that define what kind of Rider you are. Flavour them however your table likes — **Memories, Cards, Coins, Crystals, Discs, Rings**. The mechanics are identical.

An Insert is one effect with one Charge cost. Treat it like a spell you happen to keep in your pocket.

Acquisition is narrative and GM-controlled. Inserts are found, awarded, inherited, salvaged from a defeated rival, or built by an ally who knows how. You do not buy them and you do not design them unilaterally — a new Insert is a conversation between player and GM at the moment it enters play, which is where its effect and cost get agreed. A Rider who wants a specific Insert should go and earn it; that's an adventure.

Inserts live in your inventory and take no slots — they’re the size of a coin. Only the ones **loaded into your Driver** can be used. Loading or swapping an Insert takes a minute of downtime; you cannot do it mid-fight.

You start with **one Insert** of your choosing, agreed with the GM at character creation.

The Cost Ladder

This is the reference for negotiating a new Insert. It’s the Rider equivalent of spell levels — an Insert should do roughly what its cost says it does.

Charge	Combat effect
1	One target, minor. +1d6 on a hit; +2 AC for a round; a free reposition; a reaction that negates one attack against you
2	Area or control. 2d6 in a cone or burst; a save-or-lose-your-turn; a move-and-attack combination
3	Heavy. 3d6 in a burst; or solid damage plus a lasting condition; or a strong single-target effect
Charge	Utility effect
1	Advantage on one test. If the Insert’s theme plausibly covers it, this can also move a test from Impossible to a roll — the suit lets you attempt something you simply couldn’t
2	Treat the relevant stat as 6 for one test
3	Succeed automatically at something a roll could have achieved

An Insert may carry a combat effect, a utility effect, or one of each — but each is bought separately at its own cost.

Utility Inserts are not free. You cannot build Charge outside a fight: no attacks, no hits, no cinematic beats. Whatever you spend out of combat is gone, and you walk into the next fight short. Transforming purely to solve a problem also burns one of your daily transformations. Lifting a fallen girder off a trapped civilian should feel like it cost you something, because it did.

Losing Inserts

An Insert loaded in a Driver can be knocked free by a **called shot at -2**. It lands within close range, inert until retrieved and reloaded — which takes a minute, so it’s out for that fight. Inserts carried in inventory can’t be targeted in combat, but can be stolen, lost, or destroyed in the fiction. Destroyed Inserts are gone; new ones come through play.

6. Anti-Rider Threats

Most enemies are ordinary HP threats and a transformed Rider will carve through them. That is correct — a Rider *should* feel powerful against a monster of the week.

The dangerous ones carry **anti-Rider attacks**, which strip Charge instead of HP. These make a Rider’s own resource into their health bar, and they are the only thing that reliably ends a transformation early.

Keep the numbers small — the pool is only 0–8.

Threat	Anti-Rider attack
Kaijin disruptor	On a hit: 1d4 Charge , no HP damage
Anti-Rider weapon	On a hit: normal HP damage and 1 Charge
Draining aura	1 Charge at the start of each turn spent in near range
Rival Rider's Finisher	1d6 Charge , and any excess spills to HP as normal

Use them sparingly. A session where every enemy strips Charge is a session where nobody gets to be a Rider.

GM: anti-Rider attacks are how you make the rival, the counter-built kaijin, and the Big Bad *feel* different from the week's monster — not by giving them more HP, but by threatening the thing the player actually cares about.

7. Sample Inserts

Four Inserts as calibration. Use them as written, or as a yardstick when a player brings you a new one.

Crimson Blaze — *Fire / Aggression* > The gear runs hot, leaving scorch lines where the Rider stands. - **Combat (2 Charge):** All creatures in a near cone make a DEX test DC 12. Failure takes 2d6 fire, success takes half. - **Utility (1 Charge):** Advantage on any test to burn, melt, weld, or endure heat.

Verdict — *Speed / Mobility* > Harder to pin than to hit, and harder to hit than to predict. - **Combat (1 Charge):** Reaction when an attack targets you — that attack misses. Once per round. - **Utility (2 Charge):** Treat your DEX as 6 for one test.

Verdant Bulwark — *Nature / Endurance* > The plating thickens and roots. Movement slows; presence becomes immovable. - **Combat (1 Charge):** Until you move from this spot, +2 AC and immunity to forced movement and knockdown. - **Utility (2 Charge):** Treat your STR as 6 for one test.

Cogitator — *Tech / Cognition* > The visor fills with cascading readouts. The Rider stops being a person for a moment and starts being a process. - **Utility (1 Charge):** Advantage on an INT test. If the problem is one you had no way to approach — an encrypted archive, an unknown script, a machine you've never seen — this lets you attempt it at all. - **Utility (3 Charge):** Automatically succeed at retrieving a specific piece of information that exists in a system you can reach.

Cogitator carries no combat effect, and that is a legitimate Insert. A Rider who loads it is trading a fight option for the ability to crack the case — and in a modern game, cracking the case is usually the adventure.

8. Notes on Balance

Riders should feel powerful and be spending for it. Measured against a level 5 character with a d8 weapon and STR 3 — roughly 7 or 8 damage a round:

Fight length	Fighter	Rider
4 rounds (strike, strike, Insert, Finish for 5)	~30	~43
7 rounds (two Finishers, three charge-up rounds)	~52	~60

Ahead at both lengths, and by a similar margin — that consistency is deliberate. It costs two or three Advanced Aptitude slots, and Henshin is limited to L uses a day.

Note what the charge-up rounds do to the average: a Rider who Finishes twice across seven rounds still only manages about 8.6 damage a round against a fighter's 7.5, because reaching those Finishers meant three rounds of dealing nothing at all. **The exchange rate is the balance.** For comparison, a Circle Mage's Arcane Blast at that level is around 20 damage for a single burn, several times a day.

Three things keep it honest, and you should not remove any of them:

1. **Charge-up costs damage.** Reaching a big Finisher means rounds of dealing nothing. The exchange rate does the balancing so you don't have to.
2. **Charge is the health bar.** Every point spent is a point of buffer gone, and at 0 the next hit ends you. A Rider who spends freely is a Rider one blow from being a civilian.
3. **You start at 3.** A Rider cannot open with their best move — the biggest turn-one Finisher is 4d6, and anything more has to be earned in the fight.

If Riders feel too strong at your table, the first dial is the Finisher: try **(Charge spent)d6** instead of **(Charge + 1)d6** before touching anything else. **If they feel too weak,** raise the cinematic-beat award to twice a scene reliably — it's the cheapest lever and it rewards the play you want.

Do not hand out Inserts above 3 Charge, and do not let an Insert replicate the Finisher at a lower cost. Those are the two failure modes.

*For modern-day occupations, gear, and tone, see **Appendix A** of the Rath RPG Players Handbook. For advanced aptitudes generally, see **Advanced Aptitudes**. For the magic paths a Rider might also walk, see **Advanced Magic**.*